

Q IS YOGA SAFE DURING PREGNANCY? DOES IT HAVE ANY BENEFITS?

Yes. Prenatal yoga classes are widely available and are often recommended by doctors. Research, including a 2015 study from the Alpert Medical School at Brown University, has suggested that prenatal yoga is not only safe for both the expectant mother and

the baby (as measured by fetal heart rate), but it can also be beneficial for the fetus and mother while pregnant, throughout labor and delivery, and postpartum. Small studies have also suggested that, during pregnancy, yoga may have the positive effects shown below.

REDUCES

- pelvic pain and overall pregnancy discomfort
- signs of stress, depression, and anxiety
- postpartum depression.

IMPROVES

- optimism, empowerment, well-being, and social support
- birth weight (by reducing risk of preterm labor).

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Q HOW DOES MEDITATION AFFECT MY BRAIN AS I AGE?

Many areas of your brain tend to shrink with age, but Harvard neuroscientist Sara Lazar, PhD, and her team have shown via MRI brain scans that 50-year-old meditators have key brain structures similar to that of 25-year-old nonmeditators. This suggests that meditation may slow or even prevent some of the natural degradation of brain tissue that happens with aging. This is thanks to neuroplasticity (see pp.26–27). While it is likely that other factors are involved, such as lifestyle and diet, it is feasible that meditation and the resulting mindset contribute significantly. Research also suggests

that your brain can start to make these changes in eight weeks. A daily 30-minute mindfulness practice (including a body scan, yoga, and seated meditation practice) has been shown to change the brain in ways that result in better memory and improved problem-solving. A mindfulness questionnaire also showed that eight weeks' instruction and practice improved three key qualities that may contribute to a positive mindset as we age: observing internal and external environment; acting with awareness instead of reacting; and the non-judgment of inner experience.

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